stretched, trying to read my reaction. All I have to say is ‘OK’. I can only say ‘OK’ again and again. I must say it a thousand times. In each ‘OK’, it’s as if I’m trying just to buy some time for myself, process something not processable, but all I can think is, ‘Not here, surely? How could it all end like this, in the fucking Dakota Hotel in Manchester?’

At the end of the speech and the other side of all my dimly lit ‘OKs’, there’s an option offered to me. ‘You can say, I’m happy with 700 wickets and what I’ve achieved and bow out now, or you can play one last time.’ McCullum says, ‘We would be happy to give you that first Test match at Lord’s and that be it.’ One more game? My option is never to play cricket for England again or play one more time? When that first over at Lord’s went for all those runs 22 years ago, I would have run through the streets like Charlie with the golden ticket and snapped your hand off for one more. When I bowled second change for Burnley Cricket Club, I would have had to endure laughter from everyone in my team for the offer of an actual Test match for England. Now it comes, after 187 games, approaching 40,000 balls, and eight wickets short of Shane Warne’s wicket tally as some sort of gesture of consolation. That part is easy though. If it’s a choice between playing and not playing cricket, I always choose playing. All I say is ‘OK’. We finish our coffees and switch to beer. Everyone needs one.

The staff fly by around us, clearing up the drinks, as I make my excuses to go. There is no outside sense of a lifetime’s work having to stop in the hushed conversation that surrounds me. No tangible evidence of all the wickets and heartache. I’m half expecting them to ask if I’m OK, but then I realise, it’s just me that knows this. This news is mine alone. Maybe that’s always happening in these places, public bars intentionally picked for difficult private news to be broken, the recipient unable to make any scene, before the people are spat back out into the world again. As I leave, back into the sunlight and on to the tram, the world outside appears completely different to how I last left it. I think they might be amazed at how well I’ve taken it, about how drama-less the whole thing has been. They might even be thinking I took it ominously well. I’m wondering the same. I guess it doesn’t matter either way. I’m floating out of the hotel, back on the tram to Old Trafford, and I call my wife, Daniella. It’s only her that can know for now, they say.